

RESEARCH STATEMENT

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My research is primarily in experimental and behavioral economics, with additional interests in development economics and economic theory. I focus on how people learn to make optimal decisions, and why the resulting improvements are often fragile. In the laboratory, I design controlled experiments that examine how individuals learn from exposure to others' behavior and from their own experience with the decision environment. In field settings, I study how inaccurate beliefs and learning from peers shape university students' decisions to seek mental health care. Below I describe three current strands of my research agenda, which is broadly focused on mistakes in decision-making and how people learn to overcome them.

1. THE POWER AND LIMITS OF SOCIAL INFORMATION

One of the central questions in behavioral economics is why biases in decision-making do not self-correct in the long run, even when individuals have ample opportunity to learn from their own experience and repeated feedback. In my job market paper, **“Fragile Learning From Others”**, I ask whether observing how another person approaches the same task facilitates learning, and whether the improvements last once the environment changes. In a laboratory experiment with 400 subjects, participants act as hiring managers choosing between two workers after observing informative signals about their abilities. Making the optimal choice requires integrating the information in the signal, yet most participants neglect it and rely on average group abilities, a mistake that feedback corrects only slowly and partially.

Exposure to another participant's optimal choices substantially improves the quality of one's own decisions, raising the share of optimal choices by 21 percentage points. I find that the underlying mechanism is selective adoption of observed behavior rather than mechanical imitation, as exposure to *suboptimal* choices leaves behavior essentially unaffected and participants try the observed alternative after their own choice yields a low payoff. The main result of the paper is that such observational learning is fragile, as participants who initially respond to exposure lose the entire 40 percentage point difference they built over the control group once observation ends and task parameters change. Exposure appears to teach *what* to select rather than *why* doing so is optimal, and brief written advice explaining the reasoning behind the optimal rule proves much more effective, more than doubling optimal behavior among participants whom observation alone left unchanged. Observing how others approach the same problem is thus a powerful way to spread behavior but a far weaker way to spread understanding.

Others influence us not only through the behavior we observe but also through what they say. In the working paper **“Information versus Interpretation: Evidence from an Experiment on Persuasion”**, joint with fellow PhD student Bridget Galaty, we ask what makes communication persuasive. Is it that one party knows more, as in canonical cheap talk models, or that it offers an elaborate interpretation of information both already share, as in a recent literature on narratives? Integrating both within a single persuasion environment, we find that the informational advantage is the dominant channel. Messages from a better-informed party pull actions substantially closer to the recommendation, while interpretation alone adds little at every difficulty level. When given a choice of which message type to receive, a majority also prefers a better-informed party over a party with an elaborate explanation.

2. LEARNING ENVIRONMENTS THAT FACILITATE OPTIMAL BEHAVIOR

Many economic decisions require identifying and ruling out irrelevant contingencies. A contingency can be irrelevant either because it is never encountered in practice or because it is encountered but the decision maker's action does not affect the outcome. In the working paper with Jeongbin Kim and Emanuel Vespa, **“Learning to Ignore Irrelevant Contingencies: An Experiment”**, we ask whether learning to discard a contingency is harder in one case than the other. In our experiment, participants face a static decision problem where the optimal action requires realizing that some contingencies are irrelevant, and the treatment groups differ only in whether payoff-irrelevant contingencies arise with positive probability during the learning phase. We find that participants who never encounter them are 20 percentage points more likely to choose optimally when facing the static problem again, and the difference is robust to controlling for learning and beliefs. Results in our study speak to the principles of designing learning environments that emphasize the nature and composition of experience as opposed to its quantity.

In a new project, **“Descriptive Simplicity in Strategyproof Matching Mechanisms”**, I study the importance of transparent learning environments in reducing difficulties in understanding the rules of complex allocation mechanisms. Strategyproof mechanisms assign school seats and residencies on the promise that truthful reporting is optimal, yet deviations are widespread, and recent work has emphasized descriptions that expose strategyproofness. I propose an experiment that holds the mechanism fixed and varies its description, focusing on presenting the counterfactual outcomes of alternative reports so participants can verify that misreporting cannot help. The results will identify which features of a description make strategyproofness transparent. I am currently at the design stage of this experiment.

3. BEHAVIORAL BARRIERS TO MENTAL HEALTH CARE USE AMONG UNIVERSITY STUDENTS

Beyond the laboratory, I study a setting where inaccurate beliefs carry immediate stakes, as many students in mental distress do not seek professional help even when counseling is free and effective. In **“Beliefs, Information Sharing, and Mental Health Care Use Among University Students”** (*Journal of Development Economics*, 2026), joint with fellow students Idaliya Grigoryeva, Bruno Calderon, and Roberto González, and field collaborator Alejandro Guardiola, we study this treatment gap in a survey experiment with 680 students at a large private Mexican university. Nearly half of students in distress receive no professional support, and this gap is correlated with stigmatized beliefs, as three quarters of students incorrectly believe that peers in distress perform worse academically and that most students in therapy are severely distressed. An information intervention that corrects these beliefs increases the sharing of on-campus mental health resources with peers and the willingness to recommend counseling to a friend in distress, but has little effect on students' own therapy use six months later.

Given that information alone is often not sufficient to move students toward care, in the ongoing project titled **“Learning About Therapy From Friends: Conversations & Treatment Take-Up Among Students”** with Idaliya Grigoryeva, we ask whether learning from friends' experience with therapy can shift help-seeking itself. We propose to run a field experiment at a large university with free on-campus counseling, in which students attend small group sessions with their peers, and treated groups share how they or people close to them came to seek therapy and what the experience was like, while control groups discuss an unrelated campus topic. The primary outcome is subsequent use of counseling services measured in administrative records, and we are currently designing the intervention.